terrible calls to make. One father asked me: “Are we in Lebanon for any reason worth my son’s life?”

I gulped and said, yes, there was. “No words I can say can ever make up for the loss of your son, but perhaps you might find a little comfort in knowing that your son died while he was living up to the finest traditions of his country and the Marine Corps . . . America is a country whose people have always believed we had a special responsibility to try to bring peace and democracy to others in the world. And brave men and women have always been willing to give up their lives in the defense of freedom—and that’s what our marines are doing in the Middle East.”

Some men, I told another parent, go through life and never find themselves in a position where they are called upon to do one of the tough jobs that have to be done. Some face that moment and fail. But most Americans accept and do the tough jobs because they know there is no one else to do them, and they know in their hearts that they must be done.

Perhaps no words could convince a grieving father that his son had died for a just purpose; yet I firmly believed in what we were doing in Lebanon. And our efforts had seemed to be working, giving time to the Lebanese, the Syrians, and the Israelis to work out a solution to their problems.

Although some Americans, like that father, had doubts about our purpose in Lebanon, I tried to convince them that America had a duty to be there. “The Middle East,” I’d say, “is pretty much everybody’s business, it’s important to all of us.” But to have to explain this to those families—and, as I was to learn shortly, this task had only just begun—was very difficult and very, very painful.

While I tried to persuade Congress and grieving parents that the United States had to maintain its peacekeeping role in Lebanon, the civil war went on unrelentingly, with more and more attacks on the airport and the positions of French